# Dr Sam Wrighton

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## Profile

I am Chief Operating Officer of Bodhi Global Analysis, an international development research consultancy of around 30 people, where I run operations, HR, compliance, business development, logistics and communications. I took over the ISO 9001 and ISO 27001 brief fewer than three months before audit, built both management systems from scratch, and achieved certification with zero non-conformances in two audits in January 2026. I have led business development for international development and research organisations since 2020, and I achieved 40% win rates on tenders and government frameworks at both Ridgeway Information and Accent MR. I hold a DPhil in International Relations from the University of Oxford as an ESRC Scholar, and I have led the establishment of European subsidiaries in The Hague for two organisations, directing Bodhi Europe myself.

## Experience

**Bodhi Global Analysis Ltd**, London

*An international development research consultancy of around 30 people, working predominantly in Sub-Saharan Africa for clients that include FCDO, IOM, UNICEF and UN Women.*

*Chief Operating Officer* November 2025 to present

- Consolidated operations, business development, HR, compliance, logistics and communications into a single senior role, and manage operational KPIs, risk management frameworks and strategic planning with the Managing Director.
- Took over the ISO 9001 and ISO 27001 brief fewer than three months before audit, built both management systems from scratch, and achieved certification with zero non-conformances in two audits in January 2026.
- Rewrote the company's policies and processes and built the documentation framework, internal audit process and quality assurance system that certification required.
- Oversee the operations behind fieldwork across the company's country network, including conflict-affected and security-sensitive environments, with around 30 projects running concurrently.
- Lead recruitment, performance management, staff development and resource planning for around 30 people, and redesigned staff onboarding, which new joiners have since praised in their onboarding feedback forms.
- Made the case for a dedicated Finance Manager, then recruited and onboarded the post-holder, strengthening the leadership team's financial reporting and forecasting.
- Redesigned operational workflows with AI-enabled tools and set out the process logic for our automation work with the Technical Director, saving over 200 hours in a single process redesign.
- Built bespoke internal software through AI-assisted development, removing manual processes and reducing costs without any loss of quality, as part of my wider work scaling small organisations without scaling headcount proportionally.
- Oversee the sales pipeline and the company's CRM system, and manage client relationships with government and international organisations alongside the operational functions listed above.

*Head of Business Development* May 2024 to May 2025

- Led a team of six across business development, marketing and communications, and managed the end-to-end bid process from opportunity identification through to contract closure, mentoring junior colleagues in proposal development and contributing to the company's marketing and communications strategy.
- Built the bid systems and processes that increased Bodhi's win rates, and secured framework agreements and strategic partnerships with UN agencies, bilateral donors and international NGOs.
- Opened and directed Bodhi Europe, the company's subsidiary in The Hague, managing its legal incorporation, financial systems and organisational structure so that Bodhi became eligible for European Union contracts, and the subsidiary continues to operate today.
- Managed client relationships across the Middle East and North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa, including FCDO, IOM, UN Women and UNICEF, and built relationships with senior government stakeholders in defence and security.

**Wrighton BD Consulting Ltd**, London

*Founder and Senior Business Development Consultant* May 2025 to November 2025

- Established and ran an independent consultancy advising international development and security organisations on bid strategy, proposal development and procurement for UN agencies, governmental donors, INGOs and government contractors.
- Continued to lead all business development for Bodhi Global Analysis throughout the engagement, alongside my other consulting clients, until the company recruited me as Chief Operating Officer in November 2025.
- Implemented AI-powered bidding tools and professionalised pipeline management systems for clients, and developed a LaTeX templating system in Overleaf that made proposal production faster and more consistent in quality.

**Accent MR**, London

*Research Director* June 2023 to April 2024

- Led business development through public procurement and achieved a 40% win rate on government framework agreements, monitoring procurement legislation so that bid strategy adapted to changes before they took effect.
- Generated 15% of company revenue from sectors new to the company, and assembled and managed the cross-functional teams that wrote proposals for government research programmes.
- Built relationships with public sector stakeholders, including senior government stakeholders in defence and security, and mentored the bid team to deliver proposals of a consistently high standard.

**Ridgeway Information**, London

*Programme Manager* April 2022 to June 2023

*Senior Researcher* June 2021 to May 2022

*Researcher* May 2020 to June 2021

- Promoted twice in under two years, and as Programme Manager led a team of up to 24 researchers on projects about information environments, media narratives and migration for UNESCO, UN Women, the European Parliament, BBC Monitoring and the British Council.
- Designed the research methodologies for 85% of the company's projects, including sensitive political and security research across the Middle East and North Africa, West and Central Africa, Latin America, and South and Central Asia.
- Achieved a 40% tender win rate, with proposals I drafted accounting for 27% of annual revenue, and won and delivered projects worth over £500,000 for international donors and government clients.
- Authored a winning bid for a UNESCO project on media reporting of migration in West Africa, then managed its team of nine researchers and delivered the project on time and within budget.
- Led the British Council's review of trust in international relations, public diplomacy and soft power as lead author, and the report was read by UK government officials and diplomats.
- Led the establishment of Ridgeway's European Union subsidiary in The Hague, including its legal incorporation and organisational set-up, so that the company could serve European Union agency clients.

**University of Amsterdam**

*Research Assistant, then Researcher* September 2016 to September 2017

- Conducted fieldwork on authoritarian regime strategies in Hungary, Serbia and Slovakia for the European Research Council project “Authoritarianism in a Global Age”, and coordinated data across three projects with EUR 2.4 million in ERC funding.
- Presented research on authoritarian influence operations at international academic conferences, having begun as a Research Assistant supporting data collection and analysis at the Amsterdam Institute for Social Science Research.

**Leiden University**, The Hague

*Teaching Assistant* June 2013 to August 2014

- Administered first-year courses for the Bachelor of International Studies programme, coordinating between professors, lecturers and students throughout the 15 months I held the post.

## Education

**DPhil International Relations**, University of Oxford (St Cross College), ESRC Scholar 2017 to 2021

My thesis, "The Annexation of Populations: A New State Strategy?", examined migration, geopolitics and inter-state relations, and drew on 52 semi-structured elite interviews, including with senior defence and security stakeholders in Ukraine, Georgia, the Baltic states and the Netherlands.

**MSc International Relations (cum laude)**, University of Amsterdam 2015 to 2016

I achieved the highest grade average in my cohort and was nominated for both the University of Amsterdam Thesis Prize and the Daniel Heinsius Prize.

**BA International Studies (First Class)**, Leiden University, Consultancy Project Award winner 2012 to 2015

## Certificates

CELTA, International House London (2012 to 2013)

Introduction to Country of Origin Information, European Union Agency for Asylum training curriculum (2023)

## Publications

Wrighton, S. (2022) *Trust in International Relations, Public Diplomacy and Soft Power: A Review of the Literature and Data*. Policy Insight. British Council.

Wrighton, S. (2021) *The Annexation of Populations: A New State Strategy?* Doctoral dissertation, University of Oxford.

Wrighton, S. (2018) Authoritarian regime stabilization through legitimation, popular co-optation, and exclusion: Russian pasportizatsiya strategies in Crimea. *Globalizations*, 15(2), 283-300.

## Languages and interests

I speak English as a native speaker, and Dutch, French and Russian at elementary level. Outside work I am a keen cook, play cricket, sail and ski, and have travelled to 106 countries so far.